if the ‘plan’ was foolproof. After Rajiv Gandhi’s assassination, Murugan took Nalini and her mother Padma to the Tirupati temple, and the couple got married. He was a man of few words. Along with his wife Nalini, he refused to give in to the interrogators for almost three days. When Amit Verma slapped him during an interrogation, Murugan told him in front of everybody that he would kill him after his release. He was the only accused who made an attempt to escape from the SIT office in Malligai, Madras.

His death sentence was upheld by the Supreme Court in May 1999. However, on appeal, it was commuted to life term by the apex court in February 2014, citing the eleven-year delay on the part of the Centre in deciding his mercy plea.

BHAGYANATHAN (31): Key conspirator

A young LTTE activist from Madras, Bhagyanathan was the first recruit of the assassination plot and was involved at every stage of the killing. He wanted to bring out a political journal attacking New Delhi’s Sri Lanka policy but lacked the financial resources. He fell into the LTTE’s lap. LTTE activist Baby Subramaniam sold his printing press to him for just Rs 5,000 then. And the printing press became the new hub of LTTE activists and publication of LTTE literature. Bhagyanathan brainwashed his sister Nalini and mother Padma against the former Indian Prime Minister and brought them into the LTTE fold. And thereafter, he extended support to everything Sivarasan wanted to accomplish. While there were different people assigned to different tasks, anyone could go to Bhagyanathan and seek help. He was the most popular member of the gang.

He is currently serving life term in jail.

NALINI (27): Gave refuge to the human bombs

She gave refuge to the human bomb Dhanu who killed Rajiv Gandhi. A key conspirator and facilitator of the assassination, Nalini was a tough nut to crack. It took the SIT almost three days to make her talk about the crime.